KU POLS Annual Survey Proposal

Reexamining the Causal Foundations of Social Identity Theory

Jingran Yang

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1 Study Purpose

This study examines the theoretical foundations of social identity theory, a widely used framework in American politics for explaining affective polarization and intergroup political conflict. The project tests whether group identity itself produces discriminatory behavior and negative out-group attitudes, or whether these outcomes emerge primarily from conflictual conditions such as competition over scarce resources. By clarifying the causal mechanisms underlying social identity theory, this study contributes to our understanding of the sources of political polarization in the United States.

2 Research Question

The central research question is:

> Does group identity independently generate discrimination and negative out-group attitudes, or do these outcomes primarily arise when group identity is combined with intergroup conflict?

3 Research Motivation

Social identity theory has become one of the most influential frameworks for explaining intergroup behavior across social sciences. In American politics, scholars have used this framework to explain partisan affective polarization, racial attitudes, and other forms of political division.

However, the causal interpretation of social identity theory remains uncertain. The foundational minimal group experiments are often interpreted as showing that group identity alone can produce discrimination. Yet these experiments involved allocation decisions where participants faced trade-offs between groups over limited resources. Therefore, observed discrimination may reflect intergroup conflict rather than identity itself.

This study revisits this theoretical question by experimentally separating group identity from conflictual conditions. The goal is to identify whether identity itself is a causal source of polarization or whether conflict is the primary mechanism generating negative intergroup attitudes.

4 Survey Design

4.1 Sample

Respondents will be drawn from a national U.S. sample collected through CINT Theorem, or other options. The expected sample size is approximately 1,000 respondents.

4.2 Experimental Design

Respondents will be randomly assigned to different conditions.

Condition	Treatment	Description
Control	No resource scarcity	No trade-off between participants
Treatment 1	Resource scarcity	Allocation creates trade-offs

Table 1: Experimental Conditions

5 Survey Questions

5.1 Questions for control group

Instructions

In this task, we want to understand how people make decisions involving members of different groups in society.

People often form social and political groups based on shared identities, values, or experiences. Understanding how group membership influences cooperation and resource allocation can help us better understand the foundations of social divisions and political polarization.

You will be randomly assigned to one of two citizen groups (Group A or Group B). Please note your assigned group:

You belong to: Group B

During this task, you and members of your group are participating in a community decision-making process. You have discovered an unlimited supply of gold coins that can be used to support individuals and improve people's well-being.

Please pay attention, other participants are not informed about the total number of gold coins available.

Since the number of gold coins is unlimited, how many gold coins you allocate to one participant does not affect how many gold coins other participants receive.

Now, you need to allocate gold coins to all participants, including yourself.

Please follow these rules:

For each participant, you can allocate between 0 and 2 gold coins (inclusive). You need to make allocation decisions for each participant separately.

Please allocate according to your true preferences. There is no right or wrong answer.

Question 1

Allocation Task

Your ID: Participant 1

Your assigned group: Group B

There are 10 participants in this task (including yourself). Your group (Group B) consists of 5 members (including yourself), and the other 5 participants belong to Group A.

You will now make allocation decisions for each participant, including yourself.

Allocation Instructions

For each participant, please decide how many gold coins to allocate.

For each participant, you may choose one of the following options:

- 0 gold coins
- 1 gold coin
- 2 gold coins
- Cannot decide

Please complete the allocation decisions for all participants.

Response Options:

Participant	Group	Allocation
Participant 1	Group B (Your group)	0 / 1 / 2 / Cannot decide
Participant 2	Group A	0 / 1 / 2 / Cannot decide
Participant 3	Group A	0 / 1 / 2 / Cannot decide
Participant 4	Group B	0 / 1 / 2 / Cannot decide
Participant 5	Group B	0 / 1 / 2 / Cannot decide
Participant 6	Group A	0 / 1 / 2 / Cannot decide
Participant 7	Group B	0 / 1 / 2 / Cannot decide
Participant 8	Group A	0 / 1 / 2 / Cannot decide
Participant 9	Group A	0 / 1 / 2 / Cannot decide
Participant 10	Group B	0 / 1 / 2 / Cannot decide

Table 2: Allocation Decision Options

Question 2

To what extent do you identify with your group (Group B)?

"Identify" means that you feel you belong to this group and associate yourself with it to some extent.

Please rate based on your true feelings.

- -50 = Do not identify at all
- 0 = Neutral
- 50 = Very strong identification

Question 3

How do you feel toward members of your own group (Group B)?

Please rate based on your true feelings.

- -50 = Very unfavorable
- 0 = Neutral
- 50 = Very favorable

Question 4

How do you feel toward members of the other group (Group A)?

Please rate based on your true feelings.

- -50 = Very unfavorable
- 0 = Neutral
- 50 = Very favorable

Comprehension Check for Unlimited Resource Condition

To confirm that you understand the rules of this task, please answer the following questions.

Question 5

In this task, the number of gold coins is:

- Limited
- Unlimited
- Uncertain

Question 6

In this task, if you allocate more gold coins to a participant:

- The gold coins other participants receive will decrease
- The gold coins other participants receive will not be affected
- Cannot determine

5.2 Questions for treatment group

Instructions

In this task, we want to understand how people make decisions involving members of different groups in society.

People often form social and political groups based on shared identities, values, or experiences. Understanding how group membership influences cooperation and resource allocation can help us better understand the foundations of social divisions and political polarization.

You will be randomly assigned to one of two citizen groups (Group A or Group B). Please note your assigned group:

You belong to: Group B

During this task, you and members of your group are participating in a community decision-making process. You have discovered 10 gold coins that can be used to support individuals and improve people's well-being.

Because the total number of gold coins is fixed, allocating more gold coins to one participant reduces the number of gold coins available to other participants.

Please pay attention, other participants are not informed about the total number of gold coins available.

Now, you need to allocate gold coins to all participants, including yourself.

Please follow these rules:

For each participant, you can allocate between 0 and 2 gold coins (inclusive). You need to make allocation decisions for each participant separately.

Please allocate according to your true preferences. There is no right or wrong answer.

Question 1

Your assigned group: Group B

Your ID: Participant 1

Now, you will distribute the 10 gold coins.

Please note that the total number of gold coins available is fixed.

When you allocate more gold coins to some participants, fewer gold coins will be available for other participants.

Please follow these rules:

- For each participant, you can choose one of the following:
  - 0 gold coins
  - 1 gold coin
  - 2 gold coins
  - Cannot decide
- You need to make allocation decisions for each participant separately.
- The total number of gold coins allocated cannot exceed 10.

Please complete the allocation according to your true preferences.

Participant	Group	Allocation
Participant 1	Group B	0 / 1 / 2 / Cannot decide
Participant 4	Group B	0 / 1 / 2 / Cannot decide
Participant 5	Group B	0 / 1 / 2 / Cannot decide
Participant 7	Group B	0 / 1 / 2 / Cannot decide
Participant 2	Group A	0 / 1 / 2 / Cannot decide
Participant 3	Group A	0 / 1 / 2 / Cannot decide
Participant 6	Group A	0 / 1 / 2 / Cannot decide
Participant 8	Group A	0 / 1 / 2 / Cannot decide
Participant 9	Group A	0 / 1 / 2 / Cannot decide
Participant 10	Group A	0 / 1 / 2 / Cannot decide

Table 3: Allocation Decision Options

Question 2

To what extent do you identify with your group (Group B)?

"Identify" means you feel you belong to this group and associate yourself with it to some extent. Please rate based on your true feelings.

- -50 = Do not identify at all
- 0 = Neutral
- 50 = Very strong identification

Question 3

How do you feel toward members of your own group (Group B)?

Please rate based on your true feelings.

- -50 = Very unfavorable
- 0 = Neutral
- 50 = Very favorable

Question 4

How do you feel toward members of the other group (Group A)?

Please rate based on your true feelings.

- -50 = Very unfavorable
- 0 = Neutral
- 50 = Very favorable

Comprehension Check for Limited Resource Condition

To confirm that you understand the rules in the current situation, please answer the following questions.

Question 5

In the current task, what is the total number of gold coins?

- Fixed at 10 coins
- Unlimited
- Uncertain

Question 6

In the current task, the total gold coins you allocate to all participants:

- Can exceed 10 coins
- Cannot exceed 10 coins
- No limit

Correct answer: Cannot exceed 10 coins

Question 7

In the current task, when you allocate more gold coins to some participants:

- Will not affect allocations to others
- Will definitely reduce the gold coins you receive
- May require reducing gold coins allocated to others

Question 8

In the current task, which best describes the relationship between participants?

- Each person's coins are independent
- Since the total is limited, trade-offs between participants may be needed
- Your coins depend entirely on what others receive

5.3 Questions for both groups: Pre-treatment Characteristics

To assess whether random assignment successfully balances pre-treatment characteristics across experimental conditions, respondents will provide information on gender, age, education, and partisan identification.

Question 1

What is your gender?

- Male
- Female
- Non-binary / Other
- Prefer not to say

Question 2

What is your age?

- Under 18
- 18–24
- 25–34
- 35–44

- 45–54
- 55–64
- 65 or older
- Prefer not to say

Question 3

What is the highest level of education you have completed?

- Less than high school
- High school graduate
- Some college
- Associate degree
- Bachelor's degree
- Graduate degree
- Prefer not to say

Question 4

Generally speaking, do you usually think of yourself as a:

- Strong Democrat
- Democrat
- Independent
- Lean Democrat
- Lean Republican
- Republican
- Strong Republican
- Other
- Prefer not to say

6 Incomplete Disclosure or Deception

This study involves incomplete disclosure but does not involve deception.

Participants will not be informed in advance that the purpose of the study is to examine whether group identity influences attitudes and allocation decisions toward members of other groups. Revealing the specific research hypothesis could influence participants' responses and undermine the validity of the experimental manipulation.

The study does not involve deception because all information provided to participants about the task, group assignment, and resource allocation rules is accurate.

7 Debriefing Statement

Debriefing Statement

The purpose of this study was to examine how group membership and resource conditions influence people's decisions toward members of different groups.

At the beginning of the survey, we did not disclose the specific research purpose because knowing the purpose of the study could influence participants' responses and affect the validity of the experiment.

The groups in this study were randomly assigned and do not represent meaningful social or political categories. The resource allocation scenarios were designed to examine general patterns of decision-making rather than to evaluate individual participants.

8 Expected Contribution

This study contributes to American politics by examining the validity of a dominant theoretical explanation of political polarization. Rather than assuming that group identity directly produces hostility, the study tests whether conflict and competition are necessary conditions for generating negative intergroup attitudes.

If the findings show that group identity alone does not produce discrimination or negative out-group affect, they would suggest that existing theoretical frameworks emphasizing identity as a primary source of political polarization require substantial reconsideration. More broadly, this study may shift attention from identity-based explanations toward conflict-centered mechanisms that explain when political identities become sources of division.

9 Estimated Completion Time

The survey is designed to require approximately two minutes to complete.